Founder’s Dilemma

Build a startup.
Face the founder’s dilemma.

A startup grows like a flower, from seed to exit: an idea, the first customers, capital at the right time, the choices that make it bloom or wither.

kurisuchanxxx.github.io/foundersdilemma

Ctrl Studio.

01
What you learn

Every mechanic is a course concept.

The game makes tangible what stays abstract in lectures. Every system points to an entry in the app’s Learn section, with formulas and references.

Nine concepts, each with its authors.

01	**Lean startup and customer discovery** Ries · Blank	02	**Product-market fit** Ellis · Andreessen	03	**Diffusion of innovation** Rogers · Moore
04	**Unit economics and pricing** Ramanujam · Tacke	05	**Startup finance** Feld · Mendelson	06	**Team and founders** Wasserman
07	**The founder’s dilemma** Wasserman	08	**Strategy and competition** Porter · Brandenburger and Nalebuff	09	**Ethics** Startup ethics cases

One round, four steps.

Each round simulates three or six months in the life of the company.

01

Decide

Budget across R&D, marketing and operations. Price and model.

02

The engine simulates

Customers, revenue, cash, PMF, dilution and valuation.

03

Read the results

Round report, mentor commentary, market news and leaderboard.

04

Discuss

The debriefing connects the numbers to the theory.

Real startup numbers, without the real risk.

Failing, over-diluting or losing control of the board in a simulation costs part of a grade, not a life’s savings.

27

dilemmas with no right answer, drawn from real cases

8

sectors, from B2B SaaS to HealthTech and AI infrastructure

4

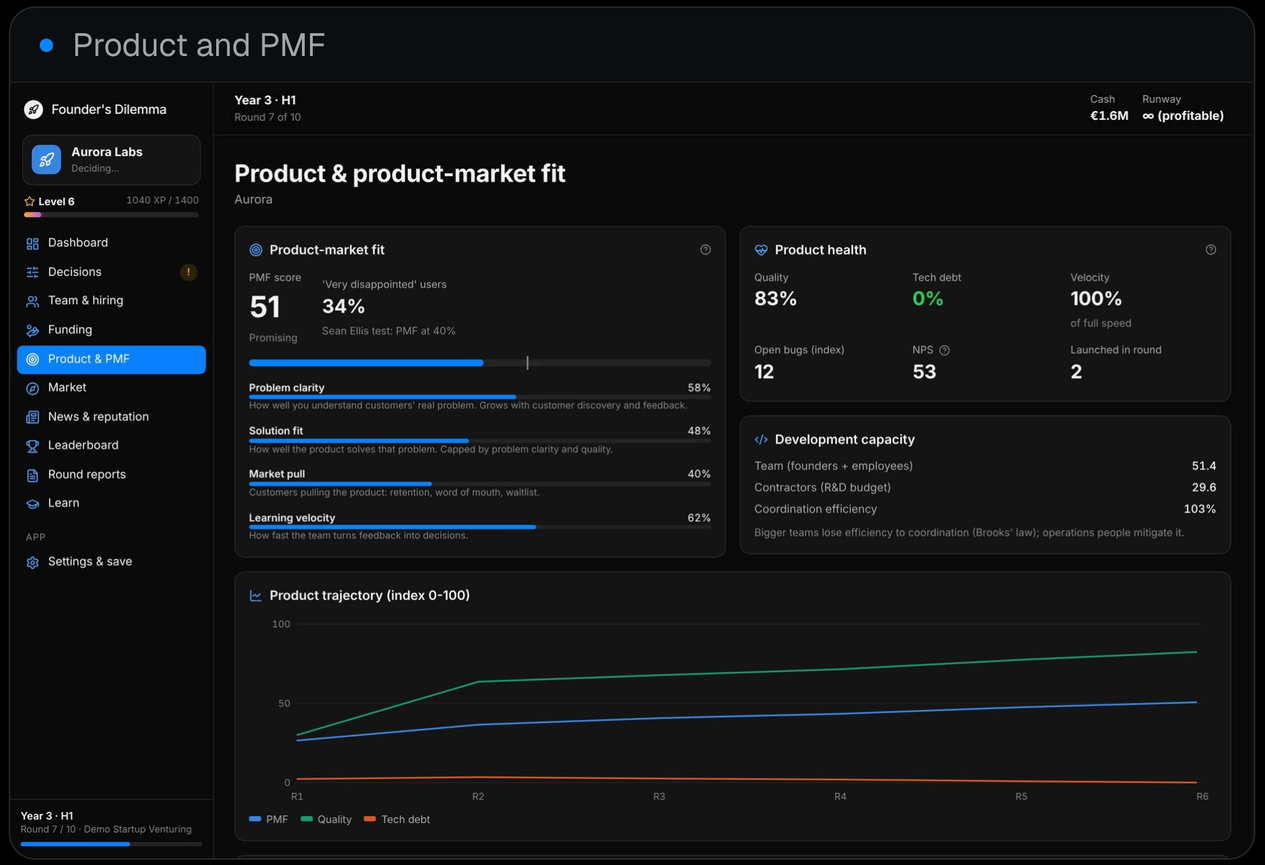
go-to-market channels, each with its own churn and brand effect

03
Inside the game

Product-market fit is measured, not declared.

It grows with customer discovery and feedback, not with marketing.

- Sean Ellis test with the share of “very disappointed” users.
- Tech debt and quality that weigh on churn, bugs and speed.

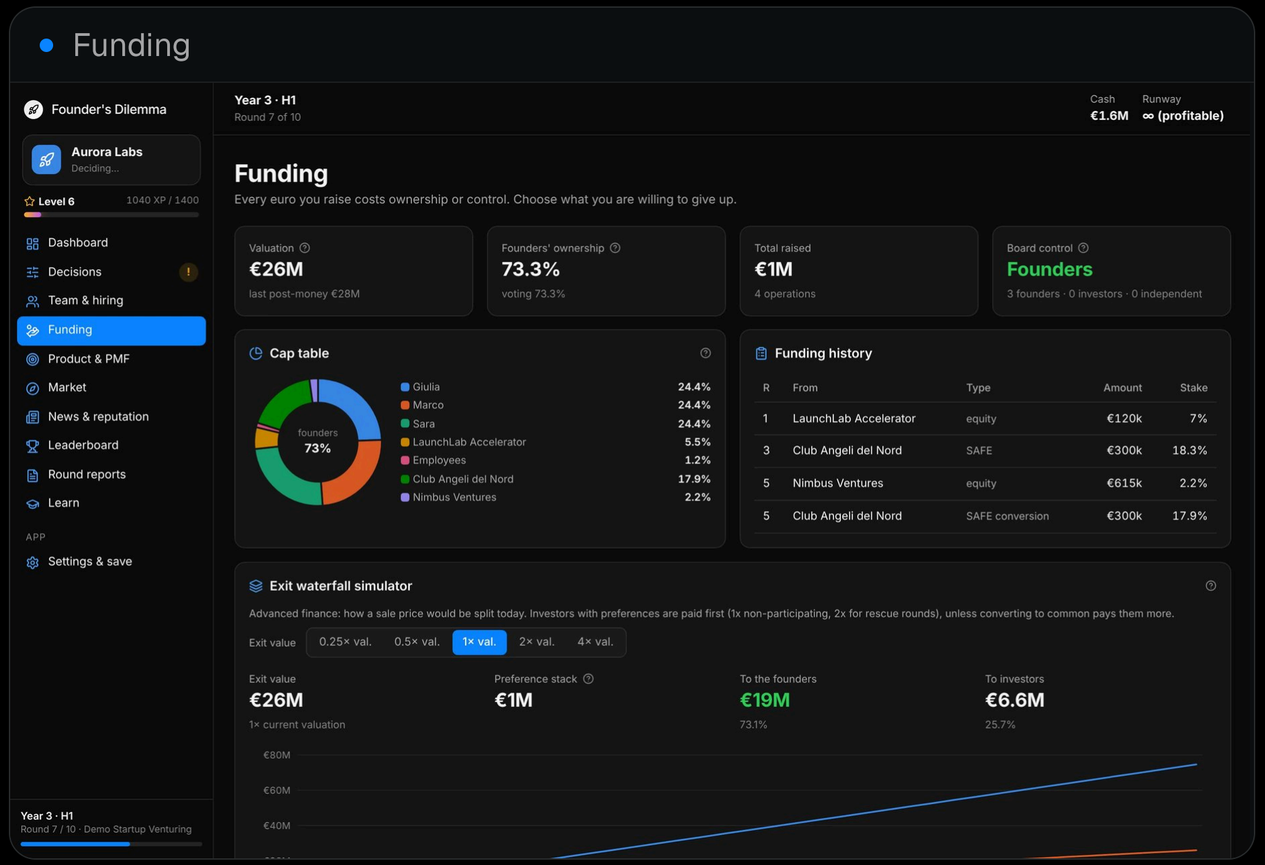


03
Inside the game

Every euro you raise costs ownership or control.

Grants, loans, crowdfunding, SAFEs and priced rounds, with investors who judge last round's numbers.

- Option pool, liquidation preferences, bridge rounds and acquisition offers.
- Contested investors: limited seats and capital for the whole class.

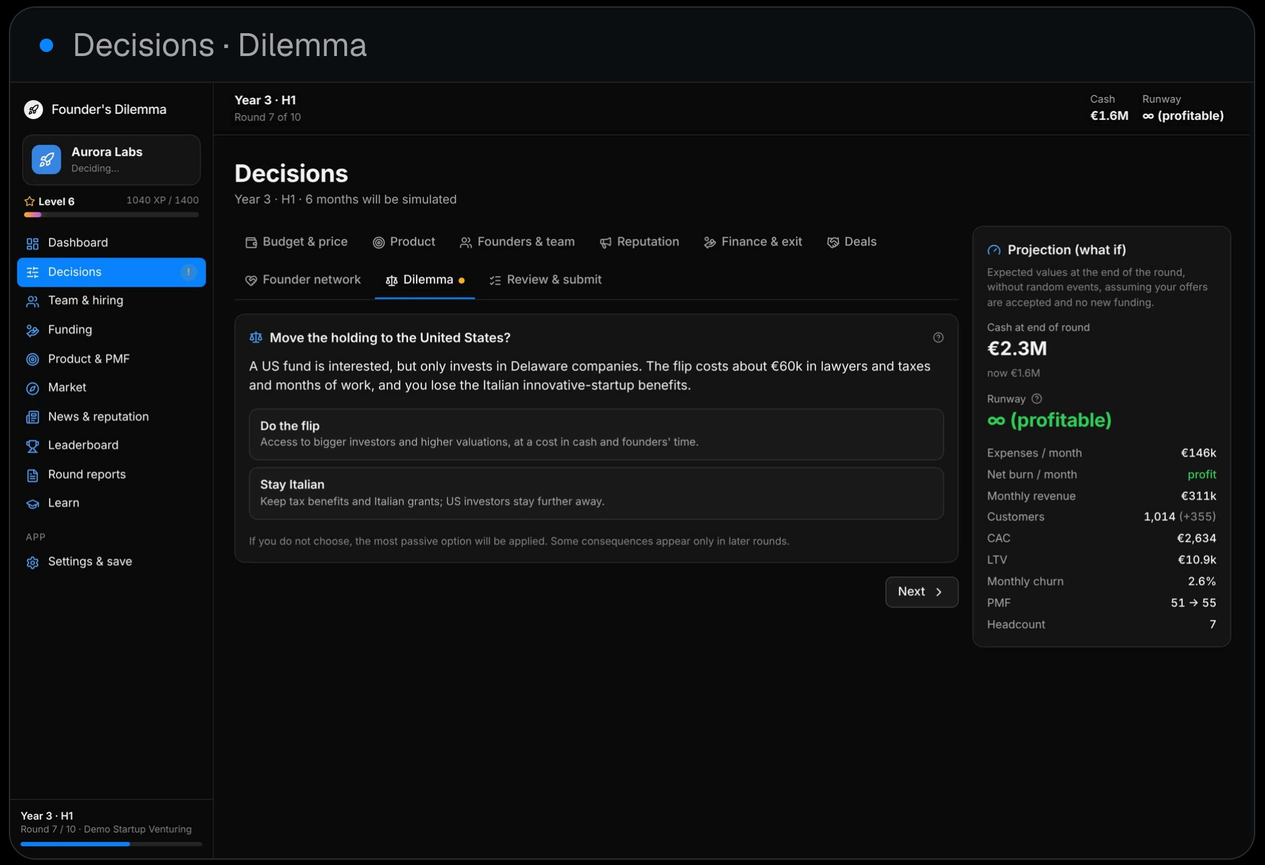


03
Inside the game

Twenty-seven dilemmas with no right answer.

A co-founder conflict, a board that wants a professional CEO, inflating the metrics before a round, a ransomware attack.

- Every choice affects cash, morale, reputation and control, often rounds later.
- Material for the debriefing: every dilemma points to a course concept.



Built for the classroom.
No server, no accounts.

From 12 to 60 students in 4 to 8 teams. Data stays on the classroom computers.

01

Solo vs bots

One team against AI competitors with three styles: lean, steady, blitz.

02

Hot-seat

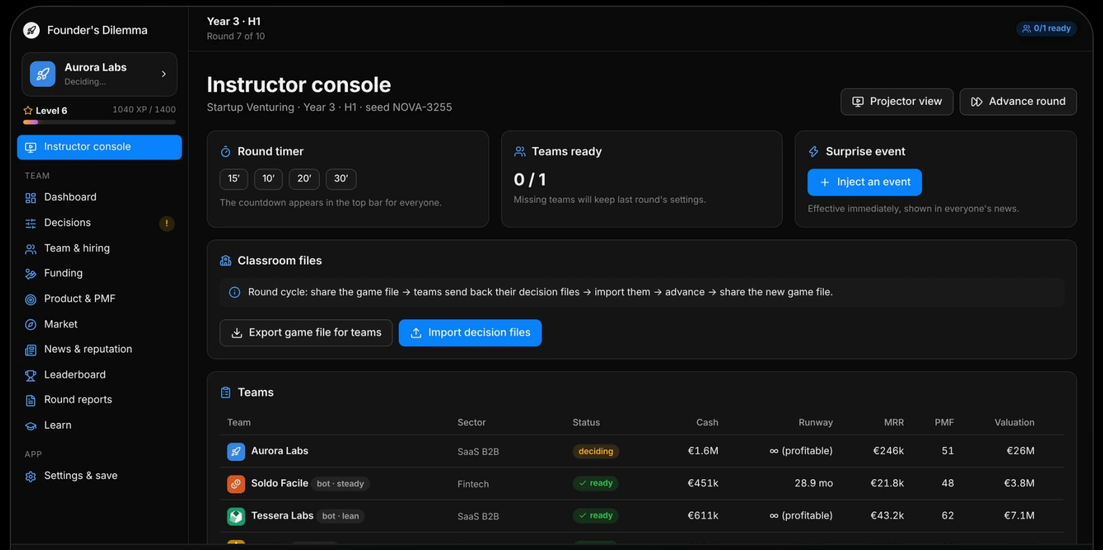
One computer or the projector. Teams take turns.

03

Classroom with files

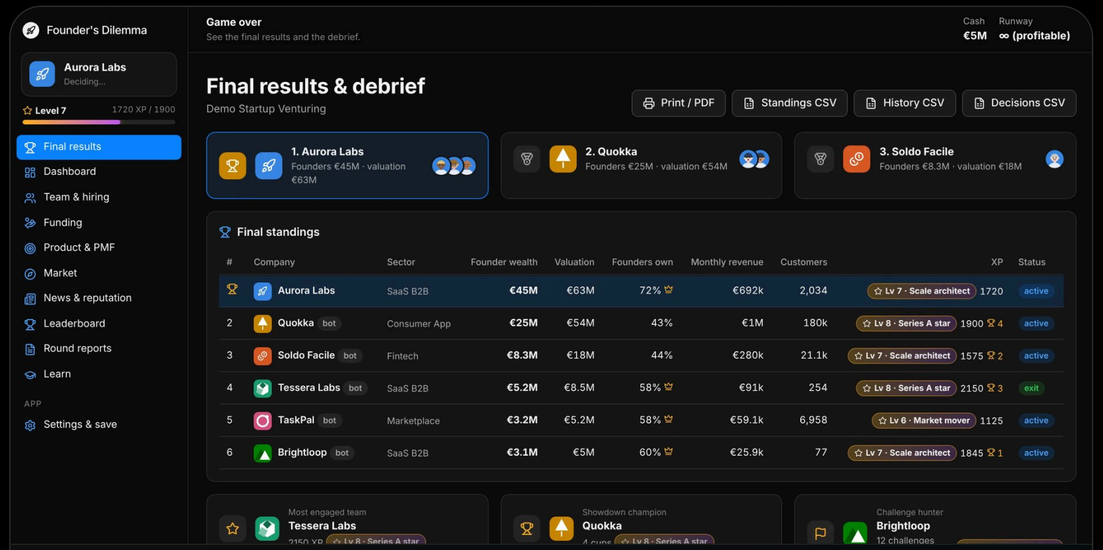
Each team on its own laptop sends back a small decision file.

For the instructor: the console and the final debriefing.



The instructor console

Round timer, projector view, surprise events, discussion prompts and CSV exports for the assessment.



Rich or King? The final debriefing.

One chart: right of the line founders keep control, higher up their stake is worth more.

The package to propose the module.

Six documents ready to go: six three-hour sessions, about 3 ECTS with individual study. In Italian; the module proposal also in English.

01 **Module proposal**

Learning outcomes, credits, structure, assessment, requirements and costs. In Italian and English.

02 **Session plan**

Six sessions with theory, game rounds and debriefing questions.

03 **Instructor guide**

Preparation, running the class, the file cycle and common problems.

04 **Student manual**

Rules, decisions, tips and the first round step by step.

05 **Assessment and rubrics**

Weights, rubrics, decision memo and final report templates.

06 **The simulation model**

Formulas, parameters and the link to the theory. For instructors and reviewers.

Try a game on your own.
The first round takes ten minutes.

Play in the browser →

kurisuchanxxx.github.io/foundersdilemma/play